The Claude Cowork Plugin Tier List

The Complete Setup Guide + The Only Honest Ranking of All 21 Plugins

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What Cowork Actually Is

Stop thinking about AI as a chat window.

If you are still copy-pasting text into a browser, you are doing it wrong. That is the "Tourist" model of AI. You visit the AI, ask a question, and leave.

Cowork is different. Cowork is a "Resident."

It lives on your desktop. It reads your files. It writes to your folders. It installs plugins. It connects to your Slack and Drive.

When Anthropic took Claude Code—a tool built for software engineers—and rebuilt it for operators, they didn't just make a better chatbot. They built a mechanical agent.

Here is the difference:

Chatbot: You paste a CSV. You ask for a chart. You download the chart.

Cowork: You point it to a folder. It reads 45 files. It builds a new spreadsheet with working formulas. It saves the file to your desktop.

I have spent hundreds of hours in this system since the beta launch. I have tested 47 different context configurations. I have broken the file permissions more times than I can count.

I suffered through the complexity so you get the cheat sheet.

This guide is the manual that should have come with the software.

The 5 Core Features

Cowork is built on five mechanical pillars. You need to understand these to operate the machine.

1. File System Access

This is the engine. Cowork reads and writes files directly on your hard drive. No more upload/download loops. It works in your environment, not a browser tab.

2. AskUserQuestion

Most AIs are confident liars. When they don't know something, they guess. Cowork is different. When it hits a knowledge gap, it stops. It generates a form. It asks you structured questions. It does not proceed until you align.

3. Plugins

These are not "GPTs." These are specialist packs. They give Cowork specific roles (Data Analyst, Sales Engineer, Chief of Staff). They come with their own slash commands and capabilities.

4. Instructions

Cowork has no long-term memory between sessions. Instructions are the "standing orders" that load every time you spin up a task. This is where you hard-code your preferences.

5. Connectors

These are the pipes. Connectors link Cowork to your live data—Slack, Google Drive, Notion, Jira. You link them once. Cowork references them forever.

The Shift: Prompting vs. Context

Here is the hard truth.

ChatGPT trained you to write better prompts. That is a depreciating skill. As models get smarter, prompt engineering matters less.

Cowork trains you to build better **context**.

That is a compounding skill.

When you write a perfect prompt, you solve one problem once. When you build a perfect Context File, you solve that class of problem forever.

I don't try to write perfect prompts anymore. I let Cowork figure out what it needs to know.

This guide covers the setup, the architecture, and the specific workflows I use to run my operations.

No theory. Just blueprints.

Setting Up Cowork the Right Way

Most people install the app, ask a question, and get a generic answer. They churn in three days.

That is because they skipped the architecture phase.

You need to set the stage before you let the actor perform.

This setup takes 30 minutes. It will save you 10 hours a week.

A) File System Access: The Foundation

First, get the plumbing right.

The Setup:

1. Go to claude.com/download.
2. Install the desktop app.
3. Upgrade to the Pro plan ($20/month). You need the bandwidth.
4. Open the app → Click the "Cowork" tab.
5. Select a root folder.

The Context Files Strategy

Cowork can read. So give it something to read.

Do not rely on the "Custom Instructions" box in settings alone. It is too small.

Instead, create a folder on your computer named `_Claude_Context`.

Inside that folder, create three Markdown (.md) files. Cowork reads Markdown faster and more accurately than Word docs or PDFs.

Here are the templates. Copy these exactly.

File 1: about-me.md

This file creates the user profile. It tells Cowork who you are.

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File 2: brand-voice.md

This ensures you don't sound like a robot.

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File 3: working-style.md

This defines the operational rhythm.

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```

The Test:

Once these files are in your folder, run this prompt to verify the connection.

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B) AskUserQuestion: The Anti-Hallucination Protocol

This is the single most important feature in Cowork.

Standard LLMs guess. They want to please you, so they make things up.

`AskUserQuestion` is a function that forces the AI to stop and interview you.

I never write detailed prompts anymore. I write a goal, and then I force Cowork to scope the project.

The Universal Task Opener:

Use this prompt to start every major project.

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The Safety Suffix:

If you are in a rush, just append this to the end of any request.

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```

C) Instructions (Global and Folder)

Context files are for reference. Instructions are for behavior.

Global Instructions

These load for *every* session. Use this for your non-negotiables.

Path: Settings → Cowork → Edit → Global Instructions

Template:

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```

Folder Instructions

These are specific to a project. If you have a client folder, put a `.clauderc` file or a specific `project-instructions.md` file in the root.

Template (Client Work):

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The Test:

Verify your instructions are active.

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D) Connectors: The Live Wire

Files are static. Connectors are live.

This is how you stop context-switching. You don't need to tab over to Slack to search for a message. You make Cowork do it.

Setup:

Settings → Connectors → Browse directory → Add → Authenticate

Connect Slack, Google Drive, and Notion immediately. These are the "Big Three."

Slack Connector Prompt:

Run this on Monday mornings.

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Google Drive Connector Prompt:

Run this before starting a new document.

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Notion Connector Prompt:

Run this to update your team.

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What Plugins Actually Are

Plugins are misunderstood.

People think they are just "wrappers" for prompts. They are not.

A Plugin in Cowork is a bundle of four distinct engines:

1. **Skills:** Specialized logic models (e.g., how to read a balance sheet).
2. **Slash Commands:** Shortcuts that trigger complex workflows (e.g., `/data:explore`).
3. **Sub-Agents:** Mini-personas that handle specific domains.
4. **Connectors:** Pre-built pipes to specific tools (Snowflake, HubSpot, Linear).

The market does not understand this yet.

When Cowork launched, $285 billion was wiped off the market caps of SaaS companies. LegalZoom dropped 20%. Thomson Reuters dropped 18%.

Why?

Because a Cowork Plugin replaces the junior analyst using those tools.

How to Install:

1. Click "+" in the chat bar.
2. Select "Plugins."
3. Browse the library.
4. Click "Install."

How to Use:

Once installed, type `/` in the chat bar. You will see a list of commands specific to that plugin.

Do not ignore this. This is the difference between a generalist tool and a specialist weapon.

S-Tier Plugins — Install These Immediately

I have tested every plugin in the directory. Most are noise.

These three are signal.

They are "S-Tier" because they provide immediate, hard ROI. If you are an operator, install these today.

A) Data Analysis — The ROI King

The Killer Feature: Anomaly Detection.

The Result: I found a $14K/month pricing error in 8 minutes.

I fed it a CSV with 45,000 rows across 3 product lines. I didn't know what I was looking for. I just told it to look.

It found a SKU that was pricing incorrectly in the EMEA region. That is pure profit.

Connectors: Snowflake, Databricks, BigQuery, Hex, Amplitude, Jira.

Prompt 1: The Blind Audit (/data:explore)

Use this when you have a dataset and no idea where to start.

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Prompt 2: The SQL Writer (/data:write-query)

Stop writing SQL. Let the machine do it.

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Prompt 3: The Money Finder (Anomaly Detection)

This is the prompt that found the $14K error.

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B) Productivity — The Chief of Staff

The Killer Feature: Synthesis.

The Result: It replaced my morning triage routine.

This plugin compounds. The more you use it, the better it gets at mimicking your decision-making logic. It connects to everything—Slack, Notion, Asana, Jira.

Connectors: Slack, Notion, Asana, Linear, Jira, Monday, ClickUp, Microsoft 365.

Prompt 1: The Morning Brief (/productivity:start)

Run this while you drink your coffee.

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Prompt 2: The Weekly Review

Friday afternoon ritual.

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```

Prompt 3: The Meeting Prep

Never enter a meeting cold again.

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C) Sales — The 90-Minute Time Saver

The Killer Feature: Non-generic Battlecards.

The Result: Pre-call prep went from 90 minutes to 5 minutes.

Most sales tools give you generic company info. This plugin reads your *internal* notes, your CRM history, and the prospect's latest news to build a strategy.

Connectors: Slack, HubSpot, Close, Clay, ZoomInfo, Notion, Jira, Fireflies, Microsoft 365.

Prompt 1: The Deep Dive (/sales:call-prep)

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Prompt 2: The Competitor Killer (/sales:battlecard)

```
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Prompt 3: The Cold Outreach

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```

A-Tier Plugins — Role-Specific Powerhouses

S-Tier plugins are universal. Everyone needs productivity. Everyone needs data analysis.

A-Tier plugins are different. They are specialists.

If you work in these specific verticals, these plugins are not optional. They are the difference between a 60-hour week and a 40-hour week.

The only reason they aren't S-Tier? They require configuration. You cannot just "turn them on." You must tune them to your risk tolerance and organizational quirks.

But once tuned, they are lethal to the old way of working.

A) Legal — The Market Crasher

The Killer Feature: Risk Tolerance Triage.

The Result: Thomson Reuters stock dropped 18%. LegalZoom dropped 20%.

Why? Because Cowork automates the "Junior Associate" layer of legal work.

Reviewing NDAs. Flagging indemnity clauses. Checking compliance against a handbook. This is high-volume, low-leverage work. Cowork eats it alive.

Since the February 24 update, the **Harvey** connector allows Cowork to reference case law and firm-specific precedent. This moves it from "Drafting Tool" to "Legal Counsel."

Connectors: Slack, Box, Egnyte, Jira, Microsoft 365.

Why It's A-Tier:

Legal work has zero margin for error. You must spend time defining your "Risk Profile" in the plugin settings. If you skip this, it will either flag everything (paralysis) or nothing (liability).

Prompt 1: The Contract Review (/legal:review)

Use this to strip-mine a vendor contract for red flags.

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Prompt 2: The NDA Triage

Stop reading standard NDAs.

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B) Product Management — The Spec Writer

The Killer Feature: The Clarification Loop.

The Result: Vague Slack messages turn into engineering-ready tickets.

Engineers hate vague requirements. PMs hate writing detailed specs.

The `/product-management:write-spec` command solves this standoff. You give it a rough idea. It asks you questions until it understands. Then it writes the ticket.

It is the most integrated plugin in the ecosystem. It talks to everything from design (Figma) to tracking (Amplitude) to execution (Jira).

Connectors: Slack, Linear, Asana, Monday, ClickUp, Jira, Notion, Figma, Amplitude, Pendo, Intercom, Fireflies.

Why It's A-Tier:

It requires you to have a product vision. It cannot invent a roadmap for you. It can only structure the one you have.

Prompt 1: The Spec Generator (/product-management:write-spec)

This is how you ship faster.

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Prompt 2: The Roadmap Synthesis

Turn noise into signal.

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C) Marketing — The Brand Clone

The Killer Feature: Voice Calibration.

The Result: Content that doesn't sound like ChatGPT.

Most AI copy sounds like plastic. It uses words like "tapestry" and "delve."

The Marketing plugin fixes this by anchoring to your `brand-voice.md` file (from Part 2). It doesn't just write; it mimics.

It connects the entire funnel: Research (Ahrefs/SimilarWeb) → Creation (Canva/Figma) → Distribution (HubSpot/Klaviyo).

Connectors: Slack, Canva, Figma, HubSpot, Amplitude, Notion, Ahrefs, SimilarWeb, Klaviyo.

Why It's A-Tier:

Garbage in, garbage out. If your `brand-voice.md` is weak, the output will be weak. You have to do the work to define who you are first.

Prompt 1: The Content Draft (/marketing:draft-content)

Never start from a blank page.

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Prompt 2: The Campaign Planner

Align your channels.

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D) Finance — The Excel-to-PowerPoint Bridge

The Killer Feature: Cross-App Workflow.

The Result: The "Monthly Business Review" deck takes 10 minutes, not 10 hours.

Finance teams spend 80% of their time moving data from Excel to PowerPoint. This is low-value labor.

The Finance plugin, built in partnership with PwC, automates this bridge. It reads your ledger, reconciles the accounts, and pushes the charts directly to slides.

Connectors: Snowflake, Databricks, BigQuery, Slack, Microsoft 365, FactSet, MSCI.

Why It's A-Tier:

Trust. You need to audit the first 10 runs heavily. But once you trust the logic, it changes your life.

Prompt 1: The Variance Analysis

Find out where the money went.

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Prompt 2: The Board Deck Generator

The ultimate time saver.

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B-Tier Plugins — Solid but Needs Your Context

These plugins are engines without fuel.

They are well-built. The logic is sound. But out of the box, they are generic. To make them useful, you need to feed them your Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs).

If you are willing to spend 60 minutes configuring them, they become A-Tier. If not, they remain B-Tier.

The Operations Suite (Feb 24 Update)

1. Customer Support

- **Function:** Ticket triage, "Resolved-to-Knowledge-Base" loop.
- **The Problem:** It doesn't know your refund policy or your tone.
- **The Fix:** Upload your `support-handbook.pdf` and `SLA-matrix.csv`.
- **Use Case:** "Draft a response to this angry ticket using the 'Empathy-First' framework from our handbook."

2. HR

- **Function:** Offer letters, onboarding checklists, performance reviews.
- **The Problem:** Performance reviews are sensitive. Generic feedback destroys culture.
- **The Fix:** Feed it your `competency-matrix.md` and specific examples of "Level 3 vs Level 4" behavior.
- **Use Case:** "Draft an offer letter for [Candidate] based on the 'Senior Engineer' band in our comp table."

3. Engineering

- **Function:** Standup summaries, incident response, post-mortems.
- **The Problem:** Every engineering team has a different ritual.
- **The Fix:** Define your "Severity Levels" (SEV1 vs SEV3) in a text file.
- **Use Case:** "Read the #incident-log channel. Draft a Post-Mortem using our standard template. Identify the root cause using the '5 Whys' method."

4. Operations

- **Function:** Process documentation, vendor evaluation.
- **The Problem:** Operations is too broad.
- **The Fix:** Use it for decision matrices.
- **Use Case:** "Compare these 3 vendor quotes. Build a decision matrix based on Price, Speed, and SLA."

5. Design

- **Function:** Critique frameworks, UX copy, Accessibility audits.
- **The Problem:** It can't "see" design intent perfectly yet.
- **The Fix:** Use it for compliance, not creativity.
- **Use Case:** "Audit this copy for WCAG accessibility compliance. Flag any language that is not inclusive."

The Financial Services Wave

Includes: Investment Banking, Equity Research, Private Equity, Wealth Management.

These launched in the "Vertical Wave" on Feb 24. They are powerful frameworks. They know how to calculate WACC. They know how to structure an LBO model.

But they do not have *your* firm's proprietary data or "House View."

You must upload your firm's `investment-thesis.md` and `formatting-guide.pdf`. Without them, you get generic Wall Street analysis. With them, you get a junior analyst.

Brand Voice by Tribe AI

This is a meta-plugin. You point it at 20 of your best documents. It analyzes them and writes a `brand-voice.md` file for you.

Use this *once* to set up your system. Then turn it off.

C-Tier Plugins — Skip Unless You're the Target

Do not install these just to look busy. They add noise to your interface. Only install if you fit the exact profile.

1. Enterprise Search

- **The Promise:** One search bar for Google Drive, Slack, Notion, and Jira.
- **The Reality:** It is only as good as your file organization. If your Google Drive is a mess, this plugin just helps you find trash faster. Clean your house before you buy a robot vacuum.

2. Bio Research

- **Target:** PhDs and Biotech operators.
- **Connectors:** PubMed, BioRender, bioRxiv, ClinicalTrials.gov, ChEMBL.
- **Verdict:** Incredible if you are doing drug discovery. Useless if you are selling software.

3. Plugin Management

- **Target:** IT Admins.
- **Verdict:** This is for the person managing 500 seats. It lets you whitelist/blacklist plugins for the org. If you are an individual user, ignore it.

4. Wealth Management

- **Target:** Financial Advisors.
- **Verdict:** Automates portfolio drift analysis and tax-loss harvesting proposals. Requires expensive subscriptions (FactSet/MSCI) to work properly.

The Connector Cheat Sheet

You do not need to connect everything. That creates security risks and noise.

Follow this tiered strategy. Start with Tier 1. Only move to Tier 2 when you have a specific use case.

Tier 1: The Universal Stack (Activate Immediately)

These activate 80% of the ecosystem's value.

- **Slack:** The nervous system. Required for almost every plugin (Productivity, Sales, PM).

- **Microsoft 365 / Google Workspace:** The file system. Cowork cannot work without reading your docs and emails.
- **Jira / Linear / Asana:** The task layer. Required for the "Action" step of any workflow.

Tier 2: The Revenue Stack (Go-To-Market Teams)

Activate if you touch money.

- **HubSpot / Salesforce:** The source of truth for customer data.
- **Notion / Confluence:** The company brain. Required for RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) workflows.
- **Zoom / Fireflies:** Meeting intelligence. Allows Cowork to "remember" what was said on calls.

Tier 3: The Data Stack (Analysts and Ops)

Activate if you know SQL.

- **Snowflake / Databricks / BigQuery:** Direct database access.
- **Warning:** These incur costs. Ensure your query limits are set before you let an AI write SQL.

Tier 4: Niche Power-Ups

Specific roles only.

- **Figma:** Product Managers and Designers.
- **GitHub / GitLab:** Technical PMs and Engineers.
- **FactSet / MSCI:** Finance professionals.
- **PubMed:** Researchers.

The Strategy:

Start with **Slack + Drive + Notion**.

That combination covers communication, files, and knowledge.

It is the "Iron Triangle" of context.

Once those are stable, add your role-specific tool (e.g., Salesforce for Sales, Jira for Product).

Do not over-connect. Complexity is the enemy of execution.

The Pattern Nobody's Seeing

Most people look at Cowork and see a "better ChatGPT."

They are missing the forest for the trees.

Cowork is not a chatbot. It is an operating system. And what we are witnessing is the rapid commoditization of the B2B software market.

Let's look at the timeline.

Wave 1 (Jan 30): The Horizontal Attack

Anthropic launched with the "Universal" stack.

- Productivity
- Sales
- Marketing
- Data Analysis
- Legal
- Finance

These are functions every company has. This was the shot across the bow. It proved that a generic agent, given the right context, could perform the work of a junior employee.

Wave 2 (Feb 24): The Vertical Siege

Less than 30 days later, they dropped the specialized warheads.

- Investment Banking
- Private Equity
- HR
- Engineering
- Design

This is where the strategy reveals itself.

These plugins are not hard-coded software. They are text files.

If you look at the architecture, a Cowork Plugin is essentially a markdown file. It contains instructions, logic, and slash commands. That is it.

There is no compilation step. There is no cloud infrastructure to manage. There is no DevOps team required.

The Barrier to Entry is Zero.

I checked the GitHub repository. It has over 2,000 stars. I watched a 22-year-old analyst build a "Supply Chain Optimization" plugin in 15 minutes.

He defined the logic. He connected it to a spreadsheet. He shipped it.

In the old world, that is a $50,000 SaaS contract with a 6-month implementation cycle. In the new world, it is a text file you swap with your friends.

The SaaSpocalypse Explained

When the market wiped $285 billion off the valuation of SaaS incumbents, it wasn't a glitch. It was price discovery.

Investors realized that the "moat" around B2B software—complex workflows, proprietary data formats, sticky UIs—had evaporated.

If an agent can read your raw data (File System Access) and execute your logic (Plugins), you do not need the UI anymore. You do not need the app.

The Enterprise Response

The big players see this coming.

PwC is already building proprietary industry plugins for regulated sectors. They are creating "Audit Bots" that live inside Cowork, pre-trained on tax code.

JPMorgan analyst Toby Ogg put it bluntly: "We are seeing $20/month seats doing 40% of the work that $150/month enterprise seats used to do."

That is the math that kills legacy software.

The "Code" Shift

Kate Jensen, Anthropic's Head of Americas, said it best: "We expect every knowledge worker will feel about Cowork the way engineers feel about Claude Code."

Engineers stopped writing boilerplate code two years ago. They became architects. They direct the AI to write the syntax.

Now, that shift has hit the rest of us.

If you are a marketer, stop writing copy. Architect the campaign.

If you are an analyst, stop writing SQL. Architect the query.

If you are a manager, stop nagging for updates. Architect the reporting workflow.

We are moving from "Apps" (tools you use) to "Agents" (workers you manage).

Anthropic shipped 10 new major plugins in 25 days. Legacy SaaS takes 6 months to ship a dark mode update.

The velocity of innovation has shifted. You are either on the rocket ship, or you are watching it leave.